

SECOND SESSION – TENTH PARLIAMENT

REPORT OF THE JOINT COMMITTEES OF THE PORTFOLIO COMMITTEE ON TOURISM AND HOSPITALITY INDUSTRY AND THE THEMATIC COMMITTEE ON CULTURE AND HERITAGE.

ON THE ENQUIRY INTO THE STATE OF OUR HERITAGE, CULTURE AND MONUMENTS AS IT RELATES TO ZIMBABWE`S TOURISM.

PRESENTED TO PARLIAMENT

(24 MARCH 2026)

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Zimbabwe, is a country that prides itself in its rich traditions and historical landmarks, and heritage sites that serve as vital links to the past, ensuring insights into the lives and practices of generations before us. Heritage preservation in Zimbabwe is a crucial cog for maintaining the national identity, fostering cultural diversity, driving tourism growth and promoting economic development at large. By safeguarding historical sites, traditions, and cultural practices, Zimbabwe can effectively connect with its past, empower its citizens, and build a sustainable future. The vital role to be played by the tourism sector is well articulated in the National Development Strategy (NDS1), and hence, the link to national heritage and cultural sites dotted around the country cannot be overemphasized.

The Joint Portfolio Committee on Tourism and Hospitality Industry and Thematic Committee on Culture and Heritage resolved to conduct an inquiry into the preservation and management of heritage, and cultural sites as they play a crucial role in driving the tourism sector. The inquiry was motivated by the government's strategic quest to promote domestic tourism, paying close attention to the role that cultural and heritage sites can play to achieve the goal.

This report presents the consolidated findings, observations and recommendations, of the enquiry into the preservation and sustainable management of various national heritage sites, cultural monuments and tourist locations across the country.

2.0 OBJECTIVES

The Joint Committee was guided by the following objectives:

1. To ascertain the state of the national monuments and heritage sites as tourism destination sites;
2. To ensure that cultural heritage sites are being preserved according to national and international standards;
3. To identify opportunities to promote cultural tourism which can contribute to economic development; and
4. To offer policy recommendations for improvements.

3.0 METHODOLOGY

The Joint Committee invited for oral evidence, The National Museum and Monuments of Zimbabwe, which is the ultimate Authority, mandated by the National Museum and Monuments of Zimbabwe Act **(Chapter 25:11)** with the preservation, and management of heritage, cultural, and monument sites in Zimbabwe. The oral evidence was received on the

26th of May 2025. It was obtained from the oral evidence that there was need by the Joint Committee to physically visit selected sites to gain first-hand appreciation of the challenges faced at the sites and the state in which they are in.

The oral evidence session was followed with fact-finding visits to the national monuments and heritage sites in Zimbabwe from the 26 May to 2 June 2025 whose aim was to ascertain the state of the national monuments and to ensure that cultural heritage sites were being preserved. The joint Committee visited the following sites; Chinhoyi Caves **(Mashonaland West)**, Dhlodhlo Ruins in **(Midlands)**, Khami Ruins (**Bulawayo**), Matopos National Parks and Rhodes Grave (**Matebeleland South**), Great Zimbabwe **(Masvingo)**, Mutarazi Falls (**Manicaland),** and the National Heroes Acre **(Harare)**. The joint committee then deliberated on the findings and proffered policy recommendations.

4.0 KEY FINDINGS

The analysis into the state of Zimbabwe`s Heritage, Cultural and Monumental sites as it resonates with tourism development reveals the following key findings:

4.1 Legislative and policy framework

Zimbabwe has a well-established legal framework, grounded in the Constitution of Zimbabwe Amendment (No. 20) Act of 2013] that celebrates the nation's diverse traditions, cultures, religions, as well as values, principles and respect for the liberation struggle. This supreme law of the land acknowledges the richness of Zimbabwe's cultural and heritage sites. More so, the Constitution is instructive in encouraging the promotion and preservation of cultural values and practices which enhance dignity, well-being and the equality of all Zimbabweans.

The principal legislation in this agenda is the National Museum and Monuments of Zimbabwe Act (Chapter 25:11) which provides for the preservation of ancient, historical and natural monuments, relics and other objects of historical and scientific value. The Act established the National Museum and Monuments of Zimbabwe (NMMZ), which is a semi-autonomous Authority and is managed by a Board of Trustees. The powers of the Board are enshrined in the Act, and importantly hold the NMMZ in trust for the people of Zimbabwe.

4.2 Powers of the NMMZ

The NMMZ is empowered to administer and manage museums and national monuments, and provide for the preservation of these monuments and other objects of historical and or scientific value. NMMZ also report on all matters relating to any monument or relic and its desirability of declaring any monuments to be National Monuments. Furthermore the NMMZ is obliged to compile and keep a register for all national monuments and relics.

4.3 Limitations of the legal framework

The existing legal framework was first passed in 1972 and was amended in 2001. There is need to close the obtaining gaps, by updating existing laws so that they are abreast with the latest developments. Consequently, the Act need to be aligned to the new Constitution of 2013, by expanding the mandate and create synergies with applicable international conventions such as the UNESCO Convention concerning the Protection of the World Cultural and Natural Heritage (1972) and World Heritage, 1970 Convention whose provisions are not mirrored in domestic law in detail for instance, the obligations concerning intangible heritage, diversity of cultural expressions, protection under armed conflict and enhanced protection and full participation of locals.

The NMMZ mandate has been expanded to include management of mass graves, inclusion of intangible heritage in the protection of tangible heritage, heritage impact assessment before any development and declaration of objects and relics as National Objects as well as protection of sites/objects during conflicts, and this must be reflected in the legal framework. It is also imperative to note that, in the absence of a distinct legal framework, the NMMZ have been operating with draft frameworks such as the framework for the management of liberation heritage and the management of mass graves and human remains. Therefore, limiting their capacity to effectively, efficiently and function sustainably.

4.4 Cultural sites and monuments Zimbabwe

Zimbabwe has 203 national monuments drawn from over 50000 recorded sites throughout the country including shrines and memorials of the liberation struggle beyond our borders particularly in Zambia and Mozambique. These monuments fall into six broad categories namely archaeological, geological, historical, liberation, living and natural heritage. Accordingly, there are 36 class one national monuments, meaning those that are fully

developed for tourism. Of these, four are listed under the UNESCO, World Heritage Sites and include the Victoria Falls, Great Zimbabwe, Matopos and Khami.

4.5 State of the museums

Museums are important for capturing national history and storing valuable artifacts. Although, the NMMZ had played its role in creating important intangible and tangible history, the museums visited visibly exhibited years of neglect. The museum at Dhlodhlo Ruins was reported to have been burn out, 10 years ago in an inferno, however, luckily the artifacts were recovered. NMMZ reported that they were engaging a private investor to partner with, in the preservation and management of Dhlodhlo Ruins. More specifically, the Agency is set to benefit from the construction of a new museum, and maintenance of the gravel road. The Committee established that the Ruins is facing serious resource limitations, with inadequate staffing levels and insufficient maintenance of its exhibition spaces. Owing to financial and logistical challenges, thereby limiting the ruins' visibility and contribution to local cultural tourism development.

Elsewhere, the museum at Matopos is small and only showcases colonial history from a Eurocentric perspective. Astonishingly, the history as related to the modern Zimbabwe and pre-colonial era is excluded, thereby not telling the whole and balanced Zimbabwean story. The Committee noted that Matopos Ruins remains one of the leading and better-equipped in the country, its infrastructure is showing signs of age and requires significant refurbishment. Several display galleries have outdated exhibits that do not reflect current research or interpretation methods of the authentic Zimbabwean narrative. Nonetheless, the museum continues to be an important hub as part of our culture and tourism.

It was further noted that the infrastructure was poorly maintained, with rusting equipment and insufficient interpretive signage for visitors. The museums lack modern exhibition techniques and adequate space to properly display its collections. There is also a shortage of specialised curatorial staff to undertake conservation and without targeted intervention, this unique collection risks further decline.

It was further noted that staffing levels are very low, with some museums operating with only a handful of professional officers who are expected to cover multiple functions, including curation, conservation, research and public education. For instance the National Heroes Acre

and the Dhlodhlo Ruins reported massive shortage of staffing to service the monuments. They are currently operating at 50% capacity of the ideal numbers. This situation has compromised the quality of museum services and weakened the capacity to safeguard collections.

The Committee also observed that digitalisation of records and collections is at a very preliminary stage. Many museums still rely on manual cataloguing systems, which makes it difficult to track objects or to provide information to researchers and the public. The lack of modern technology and inadequate information management systems hampers efforts to integrate Zimbabwe's museums into global heritage networks.

4.6 Monuments as tourism destinations

National monuments pose great opportunities for promotion of tourism. Chinhoyi Caves was reported to be significantly doing well in this regard, reporting good numbers of groupings such as schools, churches among others which come to visit the caves which are being maintained in their natural form. The caves remained a major tourism attraction drawing international tourists. The partnership between ZimParks and Far and Wide (Private Limited Company) at Mutarazi Falls was exalted as a classic example on how national monuments are well managed and preserved to promote tourism and contribute to national development.

Dhlodhlo is one of Zimbabwe's most significant stone-built monuments and forms part of the cultural landscape with its historical connection, the site has the potential to attract heritage tourists, scholars, and cultural enthusiasts from across the globe. By leveraging its UNESCO World Heritage Tentative List status and integrating it into cultural tourism circuits that link Great Zimbabwe, Khami, and Matopos, Dhlodhlo could become a cornerstone of Zimbabwe's heritage tourism.

On the other end, Khami Ruins, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, represents the architectural ingenuity and is one of the largest precolonial stone-built sites. Its terraced platforms, decorated walls, and unique stone masonry sets it apart as a site of world heritage importance. With its proximity to Bulawayo and the Matobo Hills, Khami could be integrated into a regional heritage circuit, making it a prime destination for both domestic and international tourists.

Dhlodhlo and Khami Ruins possess a huge potential to be major tourist destination centers. In their current state, the two sites are endowed with huge potential but they are a white elephant, with a huge potential to contribute to national development. The NMMZ reported that there was a potential to enter into an agreement with a private investor (G.R Godard) for the preservation and management of Dhlodhlo Ruins. A situation the joint Committee exalted as positive with a potential to revive the ruins.

The pricing models at the various tourist destinations vary depending with the category of the tourist. Local tourists are charged seemingly high fees which are pegged in foreign currency for them to access the sites. International tourists have a slightly different entrance fee which is pegged at an average of USD $10.00 excluding the activities. The money is collected and used at the various sites for their operations.

4.7 Challenges

National monuments are consumed by a myriad of challenges, ranging from inadequate budgetary support which have caused deterioration of infrastructure. NMMZ is a grant-aided agency fully funded by Treasury for employment costs, operations and infrastructure development. The entity retains revenue from entrance fees and tour guiding fees. Due to lack of funding, the Agency is not present at Provinces and Districts, in line with the country's devolution policy.

It was noted from the visits that there is need for adequate budgetary allocation and disbursements to the National Museums and Monuments to ensure the maintenance of the sites. The National Heritage and Monuments sites harbour the country's heritage and there is need for them to be kept safe. The entry fees which are paid to access the sites should be retained by such sites to supplement in their upkeep and maintenance. It was highlighted that the sites are in a deplorable state and needs financial injection for their upkeep. The huge elephant in the room is the need for resources channeled towards the sector that makes it even more attractive to tourists, both local and international tourists.

The National Heroes Acre did not have a dedicated funding for its upkeep and running which should have adequate budget. There was need to address the water pipes and infrastructure that is a threat to the graves. Together with other services such as electricity, ablution facilities and general maintenance should be routinely done at the national shrine to preserve the country heritage culture. Additionally there was need for ancillary amenities such as

restaurants, exhibition galleries etc. within some of the heritage sites so as to grow the economy within a particular site. This would invite more tourists and also have a comfortable environment to spend time at. For instance at the National Heroes Acre there are no such amenities and it makes it difficult for many people to be attracted at the facility as it lacked such “basic” infrastructure.

The road network leading to the sites is poor and this in turn tens to push away the potential number of tourists and the revenue to be generated thereof. The road network leading to the actual sites is in a sorry state. For instance at Dhlodhlo ruins the access road leading to the site is in a deplorable state. A poor road networked served as a deterrent to increase the tourism potential and the overall cost of promoting tourism growth in the country.

Most of our sites are generally aged and they need a robust facelift and need restoration. The advertising of the heritage sites is poor and there is need for improvement in this regard. This includes improving the signage and advertising infrastructure leading to the sites. This could be an excellent opportunity to explore other avenues such as the robust use of social media in advertising the heritage sites. The institutions also lacked vehicles for operations, and professional tools of trade among them, conservation and laboratory equipment.

Another point to note is around the enhancing community engagement and ownership of the sites and explore the spirituality around some of the sites where applicable such that with adequate research on the significance of the spirituality of some of these sites, it can add as a leverage that attracts many to such sites. On the other hand, as NMMZ does not hold any title deeds to the land on which these heritage sites are situated and monuments it lacks the ability to attract Public, and Private Partnerships (PPPs) as well as direct investments.

Of the staff establishment of 478 posts, 126 are vacant, representing way below 30%. The understaffed curators working at these sites are passionate and are doing the best with what is available to sell the various destinations and they have rich knowledge. There is need for resources to complement the excellent efforts being exhibited by the patriotic sons and daughters of the country. However there is room to improve their skills in-order for the tour guides to speak with a view of advancing the local narrative and move away from the colonial mentality.

5.0 OBSERVATIONS

Based on the findings, the following key observations were made by the Joint Committee:

1. The NMMZ mandate needs to be reviewed as it lacks fails to recognize the potential of national heritage sites in promoting both domestic and international tourism, as well as national development.
2. The majority of the national heritage sites visited showed signs of years of neglect, rains induced ground creepage down the site slopes has increased the incidence of wall cracks, bulges, and collapses, especially at Dhlodhlo and Khami ruins. At the National Heroes Acre, water pipes burst, continue to threaten the graves` existence. There is lack of proper water development at the sites.
3. Most of the sites lack tourism supporting infrastructure, such as shops for refreshments and curios. Matopos, Khami, and Dhlodhlo are befitting examples.
4. The authority to perform traditional rituals or any other rituals is only granted by the Head Office upon submission of a written request, a scenario that subjects the role of local communities, leaders, or traditional leadership to the periphery. This leaves out local communities out of the matrix when it comes to sites within their localities and defeats community engagement.
5. There were huge quarry mining operations within the precinct of Khami ruins. Dust and noise pollution as well as fear of blasting effects on the ruins, were a major concern to the legislators.
6. The national monuments have no well-defined and clearly marked boundaries, for example at Dhlodhlo, Matopos and Khami ruins. This poses a challenge which regulate further developments, particularly from tourism and mining sector.
7. The Cultural Heritage and monuments sites are poorly advertised and marketed. Great Zimbabwe is marketed through their central reservations office in Harare with the officers stationed at the site with no direct access.
8. Most, if not all of the sites visited are not easily accessible to Persons with Disabilities (PWDs). The steep slopes, and terrains associated with sites such as at Great Zimbabwe, Chinhoyi caves, Mutarazi, Matopos and Khami are inaccessible to many with various types of disabilities. The lighting inside the Chinhoyi caves leaves a lot to be desired for people with various impairments.

9. There is potential in enriching the Information available about our heritage, cultural and monuments sites, such as Chinhoyi caves water depth, and possible linkage with a similar site in Kariba can be explored. There are huge gaps in knowledge particularly about our African Heroes like Lobengula, Mzilikazi and others as they relate to our heritage, culture and the monuments such as at Dhlodhlo ruins. It was also observed that the spirituality of these sites was often downplayed, to the detriment of cultural uses of the sites and implications to tourism and preservation of the sites.

10. The roads leading to the sites are generally in poor states, and this in turn tends to push away the potential number of tourists and the revenue to be generated thereof. Roads leading to Dhlodhlo ruins, as well as that to Mutarazi are in deplorable states.

6.0 RECOMMENDATIONS

In light of the findings and observations, the following recommendations were proposed by the Committee for adoption by the House: -

1. The Ministry of Home Affairs and Cultural Heritage to review the NMMZ Act by July 2026 in order to better align with the Constitution, including heritage management agreements, greater community participation, impact assessments of archaeological / heritage sites in promoting both domestic and international tourism.
2. There is a need for Treasury to provide adequate budgetary allocation and timely disbursement of the funds to the National Museums and Monuments, by January 2026, to ensure the general routine maintenance of these critical sites is carried out to ensure local and international tourism booms.
3. The Ministry of Agriculture, Lands, Water, Fisheries and Rural Development to ensure that Programmes such as the Presidential borehole drilling must be extended to cultural heritage and monument sites across the country, by June 2026.
4. The Ministry of Tourism and Hospitality Industry should assist locals to establish and run tourism infrastructure such as shops for refreshments, curios such as the ones at Matopos, Khami and Dhlodhlo. A comprehensive plan should be put in place by 31 January, 2026.
5. The Ministry of Home Affairs and Cultural Heritage, together with the Ministry of Local Government and Public Works should enforce the existing robust and clear legal and policy frameworks that uphold traditional leaders as the custodians of our culture and heritage.

6. The Department of Physical Planning under the Ministry of Local Government and Public Works should ensure that national monuments have well-defined and clearly marked boundaries by December, 2026.
7. The Ministry of Tourism and Hospitality Industry to improve the marketing strategies and ensure that cultural heritage sites and monuments are vigorously marketed on both physical and digital platforms and strengthen synergies between NMMZ and Zimbabwe Tourism Authority (ZTA) by May, 2026.
8. The Ministry of Home Affairs and Cultural Heritage should ensure that cultural heritage sites and monuments are made accessible to PWDs and to consult the PWDs on how to make the sites more accessible and user-friendly by July 2026.
9. There is need to invest more in the research, documentation and storage of pertinent cultural and monumental information by the NMMZ. Emphasis must be put on connecting the spirituality of these people and the sites with regards to the preservation, protection and sustainable tourism utilisation by December, 2026.
10. The Ministry of Transport and Infrastructure Development should prioritise construction and rehabilitation of the road network that leads to access to tourist sites by December, 2026.
11. The Ministry of Home Affairs and Cultural Heritage should ensure that the pricing models for locals are reviewed for them to be affordable to allow the promotion of domestic tourism. Additionally, International Tourists should pay more than the current average entry price of USD $10.00 by January, 2026

8.0 CONCLUSIONS

The Committee's enquiry into the state of cultural heritage sites, museums, and monuments in Zimbabwe has revealed both the immense potential these assets hold for tourism promotion and the significant challenges currently limiting their impact. While heritage resources such as Dhlodhlo, Khami, and the Matopos carry great historical, cultural, and economic value, their preservation and effective utilisation are undermined by inadequate infrastructure, chronic underfunding, poor connectivity, and limited skilled staffing.

The analysis reveals a mixed picture of the obtaining gaps and the huge potential for the preservation, protection and sustainable utilisation of Zimbabwe`s Cultural heritage sites and monuments. It further calls stakeholders to action in a more holistic and collaborative effort that recognises the principles of the whole of government approach to development. Without

urgent interventions, these challenges risk diminishing the role of heritage in positioning Zimbabwe as a competitive tourism destination. However, with appropriate investment in infrastructure, improved funding mechanisms, enhanced staffing capacity, and stronger connectivity, cultural heritage can serve as a powerful driver of economic growth, job creation, and national identity. The Committee therefore emphasises the need for deliberate policy action and sustained resource allocation to safeguard these national treasures and unlock their full potential as enablers of tourism development.